by the Obama administration, which combined and upgraded the two sets of talks into the Strategic and Economic Dialogue starting in 2009. With Obama himself addressing the gathering, and with the Americans represented by Obama's secretaries of state and the treasury, the highest-level imprimatur was placed on the annual meeting.

Just as importantly—perhaps even more so—America's leaders assumed in the flush of post–Cold War triumphalism that a China that was increasingly treated as a near peer of the United States and pulled into the global system would eventually, if fitfully, begin to manifest liberal tendencies. Harking back to dreams shared by Christian missionaries in the nineteenth century, US policy makers and business leaders believed that positive reinforcement in the form of diplomatic respect, earnest attempts at cooperation, and avoidance of topics like human rights would eventually catalyze an evolution in China's socioeconomic-political system. The benefits of following a liberal course were so self-evident, American leaders believed, that even authoritarian Chinese leaders would be forced to grant more power to their middle class, if only to keep it supportive, and to further open their society, since development ultimately depended on cultural changes that ensured a fertile field for further capitalist-style modes of organization. They could, they believed, change China. It was the bet of the century.

The Chinese Behemoth

China has indeed been changed over the past four decades, far beyond the dreams of Nixon and his successors. It is a dominant, if not the dominant, global power by a host of measures: industrial production, export of finished goods, provision of foreign aid, size of urban areas, military strength, and diplomatic activity, to name some of the more prominent. For most observers, it is China's massive economic growth that makes it a great power. By purchasing power parity (PPP) measurement, it is the world's largest economy, at $25.3 trillion in 2018,